Ten Questions Families Ask When a Parent Suddenly Needs More Help

Plain answers to general questions, and when to take yours to a professional.

You're not the first family to stand in a hospital hallway wondering what “more help” means. These are the questions that come up most, answered in general terms.

None of the answers is about Mom in particular. Where a question needs someone who knows her, the answer says who to ask.

1 What does “needs more help” actually mean?

Usually it means help with everyday activities. Medicare's discharge checklist lists them: bathing, dressing, using the bathroom, climbing stairs, cooking, food shopping, house cleaning, paying bills, getting to appointments. The phrase doesn't say which of those, or how much. Finding that out is what this step is for. [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you were told she needs help and nobody said with what. Ask the discharge planner or her doctor to name the activities.

2 Doesn't her diagnosis tell us how much help she'll need?

Not by itself. A diagnosis names a condition. It doesn't describe her mornings. How much care a person needs varies from person to person and often changes over time, which is why the roadmap asks you to write down what you see her do this week and bring it along with the diagnosis. [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to know what her condition means for the months ahead. That's a question for her doctor.

3 What are ADLs, and why does everyone keep asking about them?

ADLs are activities of daily living: bathing, dressing, using the toilet, moving to and from a bed or chair, caring for incontinence, and eating. Most long-term care is help with these basic personal tasks, not medical care, so they're the first thing a professional asks about. [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you're not sure whether what you're seeing counts as needing help with one of them. Describe what you saw and let them judge.

4 Who decides how much care she needs?

Her clinicians assess her, and the family supplies what they can't see. In the hospital, discharge planning may be handled by a dedicated discharge planner, a social worker, a nurse or another member of staff, and Medicare's checklist calls the patient and the caregiver important members of the planning team. At home, a geriatric care manager is one kind of professional who can evaluate in-home care needs. [4] [1] [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** a decision about her care is being made and nobody has assessed how she manages at home.

5 She says she's fine. I'm seeing something else. Who's right?

Possibly both. Each of you is describing part of the week. The National Institute on Aging says the best way to know what someone needs is to ask them directly, so write her account down first. Then write what you saw, with the day. Don't settle the difference yourselves. Bring both accounts. [6]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the two accounts are far apart on something that worries you.

6 What should we be writing down?

What she does on her own, what she does with help and who helps, what has changed since the hospital, and what nobody has seen. Add the date and who saw it. Write what happened, not what you think it means.

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you've noticed something and can't tell whether it matters. Write it down and mention it.

7 What paperwork should we have?

Written discharge instructions that you can read and understand, a summary of her current health, a full drug list (prescriptions, over-the-counter drugs, vitamins and supplements, with any changes made during the stay), and the names and phone numbers of people to call. If you left without one of these, call and ask for it. [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you've read the instructions and don't understand them. Ask the person who wrote them.

8 Can we adjust her medications if something seems off?

No. Write down what you noticed and ask. The National Institute on Aging tells older adults not to stop a prescription unless the doctor says it's okay, and to talk with a doctor or pharmacist when unsure. A family helping with the pill box should hold to the same rule. [7]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** what's in the house doesn't match the written list, or a dose was missed or doubled. Call the pharmacist or the prescriber.

9 We're already doing a lot for her. Does that count as care?

Yes. About 80 percent of care at home is provided by unpaid caregivers. List who does what and when, because the professionals need to know what is already holding things together. [8] [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you're doing a task nobody showed you how to do. Medicare's checklist says to ask the staff to show you and to let you practice.

10 Where do we go with a question nobody here can answer?

Clinical questions go to her doctor, her nurse or her pharmacist. To find local services for older adults, the Eldercare Locator, a public service of the federal Administration for Community Living, is at 1-800-677-1116. A geriatric care manager, usually a licensed nurse or social worker, works with families to identify needs and find services in the community. [9] [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you don't know which kind of professional a question belongs to. Ask any of them and they'll point you.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer any question about Mom herself. Anything that depends on her condition, her medications or her safety needs someone who has assessed her.

Ready for the next step?

You have plain answers to the general questions. The care interview is where the questions become about Mom: it walks you through her situation area by area and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Your Discharge Planning Checklist (CMS Product No. 11376)
2. Administration for Community Living, How Much Care Will You Need?
3. Administration for Community Living, What is Long-Term Care?
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
5. National Institute on Aging, Services for Older Adults Living at Home
6. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
7. National Institute on Aging, Taking Medicines Safely as You Age
8. Administration for Community Living, Who Will Provide Your Care?
9. Administration for Community Living, Eldercare Locator